

AND THEN THERE WERE...

Nobody dominated the news in 2007 like Karat but there were others whose words and deeds caught the nation's attention

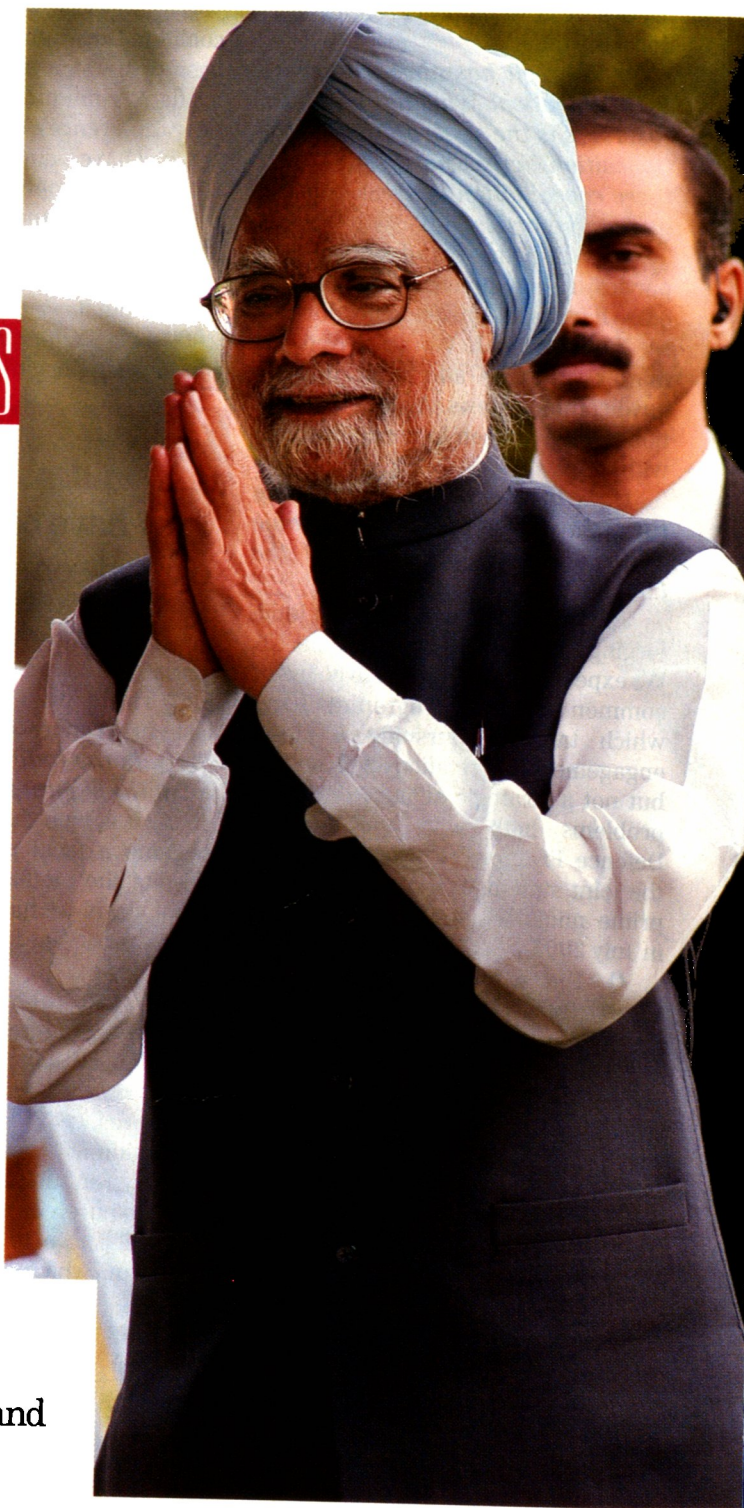
Manmohan Singh

ANNUS HORRIBILIS

It could have been the most memorable year for Prime Minister Manmohan Singh. Instead, it closely resembles annus horribilis. Tripped by his own party, adulterous allies and an adamant Left, Manmohan finds himself at the end of a term with little to write down the memory lane. The N-deal may dominate the political mind space but the fact is that little else went right for Manmohan. Yes, the economy did grow at 9 per cent and the Sensex did cross the 20,000 mark but that was fuelled by private enterprise and consumption. Descriptions of the Government range from a charitable "lame duck" to a harsh "ground zero" as it has been at a standstill since the February assembly elections. Typically, single-digit parties have used their veto with effect. The existence of over 150 Goms best exemplifies the civil strife in the Cabinet. Manmohan's integrity is yet intact but has been found dented by the silent submission on fundamental economic and political issues—the presence of tainted ministers, the funding of PSUs, fiscal profligacy and rising trend of crony capitalism. Just as he expected his colleagues and allies to stay the course with him on the N-deal, the middle-class expected him to be the prime minister they dreamt he would be. Yes, this is a raucous coalition and his is not the last word in this regime but that is an apologetic alibi. He was expected, as in 1991, to change the course of political discourse but the prime minister in Manmohan did not assert his intellect. His own political legacy and popular expectations are both in tatters.

by Shankar Aiyar

THE MIDDLE CLASS, which saw him as the man who could forever change India's destiny, is now witness to him wilting and yielding at every turn



SIPRA DAS